

PRACTICAL HANDBOOK · 2026 EDITION

The Complete Beginner's Guide to Artificial Intelligence

Learn AI Tools, ChatGPT, Prompt
Engineering, Image Generation, Video
Generation, AI Automation, AI Agents,
and Productivity Workflows

FROM ZERO TO PRACTICAL MASTERY
NO CODING REQUIRED

2026

How to Use This Book

This handbook is built for absolute beginners who want practical results—not academic theory. You will learn what AI is, which tools to use, how to write strong prompts, and how to apply AI to real work.

Who this book is for

Students, freelancers, entrepreneurs, marketers, creators, office workers, and anyone who wants to use AI confidently in daily work.

What you will be able to do

- Explain AI in plain language and choose the right tool for a task
- Use ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity, and NotebookLM professionally
- Write powerful prompts for writing, research, marketing, and analysis
- Generate images, video, and audio with modern AI tools
- Build simple automations and understand AI agents
- Complete real projects you can reuse in business or freelancing

How to read it

Read Parts 1–4 in order. After that, jump to the sections you need—images, video, automation, or projects. Every chapter ends with action steps. Do them. Skill comes from practice, not passive reading.

TIP

Keep a notes doc titled *AI Playbook*. After each chapter, save your best prompts and workflows. By the end you will own a personal operating system for AI.

Print & PDF notes

This file is sized for a **160 × 220 mm** handbook. Use your browser's Print dialog → Save as PDF, enable backgrounds, and set margins to default (CSS already defines page size).

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PART 1

Understanding AI

Start here. You will learn what artificial intelligence actually is, why it suddenly feels everywhere, and how modern systems produce useful answers from patterns in data.

What Is Artificial Intelligence?

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is software that performs tasks that normally require human intelligence: understanding language, recognizing images, making recommendations, or generating new content.

Definition

Think of AI as a very fast pattern-matching engine. It studies huge amounts of examples, learns statistical relationships, and then applies those patterns to new situations. It does not “think” like a person—but it can produce outputs that look intelligent when used well.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

When Netflix suggests a show, YouTube ranks the next video, or Google Maps predicts traffic, an AI model is comparing your behavior to patterns learned from millions of other users.

A short history (the useful version)

- **1950s–1980s:** Rules and logic systems. Computers followed hand-written instructions.
- **1990s–2010s:** Machine learning. Systems learned from data (spam filters, recommendations).
- **2012+:** Deep learning. Neural networks made image and speech recognition practical.
- **2017+:** Transformers. A new architecture unlocked modern language models.
- **2022–2026:** Generative AI went mainstream—ChatGPT, image/video generators, agents, and workplace copilots.

Three types you must know

Type	Meaning	Example
Narrow AI	Good at one job or a narrow set of jobs	Spam filter, face unlock, translation
Generative AI	Creates new text, images, audio, video, code	ChatGPT, Midjourney, Veo, Suno
General AI (AGI)	Human-level flexible intelligence across domains	Not achieved yet

Everything you use today is Narrow AI—often generative. AGI is a research goal, not a product you can buy.

Why AI matters now

Three shifts happened at once: models got dramatically better, interfaces became chat-simple, and tools connected to everyday apps (Docs, email, browsers, design tools). That combination turned AI from a lab topic into a daily productivity layer.

Where you already use AI

Product	What AI does
Netflix / YouTube / TikTok	Ranks content likely to keep you watching
Google Maps	Predicts routes, traffic, and arrival times
Amazon	Recommends products and detects fraud patterns
Banking apps	Flags unusual transactions
Healthcare tools	Assists imaging review, triage, documentation

Common myths

MYTH → REALITY

- **“AI is conscious.”** No. It predicts likely next words or pixels.
- **“AI always tells the truth.”** No. It can hallucinate confident wrong answers.
- **“AI will replace all jobs overnight.”** Unlikely. It changes tasks first; people who use AI replace people who don’t.
- **“You need to code.”** No. Chat interfaces are enough to start—and this book assumes zero coding.

The near future (practical view)

Expect more multimodal tools (text + image + voice + video in one chat), more agents that take multi-step actions, and deeper workplace integration. Your advantage is not memorizing every product—it is learning transferable skills: prompting, verification, workflow design, and tool selection.

Key Takeaways

- AI is pattern recognition and generation at scale—not human consciousness.
- Today’s tools are Narrow / Generative AI.
- You already use AI daily; the new skill is directing it deliberately.
- Always verify important facts; fluency $\neq$ accuracy.

Action Steps

1. List five apps you use daily and note where AI might already be helping.
2. Open ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini and ask: “Explain AI to me like I’m 14, with three everyday examples.”
3. Create an AI Playbook document for prompts and notes.

EXERCISE — SPOT THE AI

Pick one shopping site and one social app. Write three specific AI decisions each product is making for you (recommendations, ranking, moderation, search).

CHAPTER 2

How Modern AI Works

You do not need a computer science degree. You do need a mental model so AI stops feeling like magic—and so you know why prompts, context, and verification matter.

The five-building-block model

1. **Data:** Text, images, audio, code, and other examples the system learns from.
2. **Training:** Adjusting millions/billions of internal knobs so predictions get better.
3. **Model:** The trained brain that can respond to new inputs.
4. **Inference:** Using the model to answer your prompt.
5. **Tools & retrieval:** Optional extras—web search, your files, calculators, apps.

ANALOGY

Training is like studying for years. Inference is like taking an open exam in seconds.

Retrieval is like being allowed to open a specific binder of your notes during the exam.

Neural networks & deep learning

A neural network is a stack of simple math units (neurons) arranged in layers. “Deep” learning means many layers. Early layers catch simple patterns; later layers catch complex ones (edges → shapes → objects, or letters → words → ideas).

Transformers (why ChatGPT exists)

Transformers are the architecture behind modern large language models (LLMs). Their key trick is **attention**: the model learns which words in a passage matter for predicting the next word. That makes long-range context possible (“it” refers to which noun?) and scales extremely well.

Tokens, not words

Models read **tokens**—chunks of text that may be whole words or pieces (`ing` , `Chat` , `GPT`). Limits are measured in tokens. Rough rule: English ≈ 0.75 words per token (or ~ 100 tokens ≈ 75 words).

Context windows

The **context window** is how much text the model can consider at once (your prompt + conversation + uploaded material). Bigger windows help with long documents—but stuffing irrelevant text still hurts quality.

Concept	Plain meaning	Why you care
Parameters	Internal learned weights	Bigger $\neq$ always better; quality and training matter
Context window	Short-term working memory	Limits how much you can paste at once
Fine-tuning	Extra training for a specialty	Makes a model better at a narrow style/task
RAG / Retrieval	Fetch relevant docs, then answer	Grounds answers in your files or the web
Hallucination	Confident wrong output	Verify facts, citations, numbers, quotes

Fine-tuning vs. prompting vs. retrieval

- **Prompting:** Guide the base model with instructions and examples. Fastest for beginners.
- **Retrieval:** Attach or search documents so answers cite your sources (NotebookLM, Perplexity, enterprise RAG).
- **Fine-tuning:** Retrain on specialized data. Powerful but usually overkill for individuals.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATION

Most beginners get 80% of results from better prompts + better source material, not from switching models every week.

Key Takeaways

- Models predict patterns learned from data; they do not look up a single ‘truth database’ by default.
- Tokens and context windows set hard limits on what fits in one go.
- Retrieval and tools reduce hallucinations when accuracy matters.
- Prompting is your primary control surface.

Action Steps

1. Ask an AI: “Explain transformers using a kitchen analogy.”
2. Paste a 1-page article and ask for a summary—then ask which details it might have guessed.
3. In your AI Playbook, note: Token $\approx$ word piece; Context = working memory; Verify = non-negotiable.

PART 2

The AI Ecosystem

AI is not one app. It is a landscape of tools. This part gives you a map so you can stop collecting random subscriptions and start choosing deliberately.

Understanding AI Tool Categories

When someone says “I use AI,” ask: which category? Text, search, image, video, audio, coding, productivity, automation, or agents each solve different jobs.

1. Text generation AI

Job: Draft, rewrite, brainstorm, analyze, tutor, plan.

Examples: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, DeepSeek.

Best for: Writing and thinking work. **Watch out for:** factual errors without sources.

2. Search AI

Job: Answer questions with live web context.

Examples: Perplexity, You.com.

Best for: Current events, product comparisons, quick research with links.

3. Research AI

Job: Go deeper—multi-source synthesis, long-document understanding.

Examples: NotebookLM, Perplexity deep research modes, ChatGPT/Gemini research features.

Best for: Reports, literature-style overviews, studying your own materials.

4. Image generation AI

Examples: Midjourney, Flux, DALL·E, Ideogram, Leonardo.

Best for: Concept art, ads, thumbnails, mockups. **Weak at:** perfect typography (except specialists like Ideogram), legal/likeness-sensitive work without care.

5. Video generation AI

Examples: Google Veo, OpenAI Sora, Runway, Kling, Pika.

Best for: Short clips, storyboards, social drafts. Still costly/limited for long-form cinema.

6. Audio generation AI

Voice: ElevenLabs, PlayHT. **Music:** Suno, Udio.

Best for: Voiceovers, podcasts drafts, placeholder scores. Check licensing before commercial use.

7. Coding AI

Examples: Cursor, Windsurf, GitHub Copilot, Replit AI.

Best for: Building software faster. Beginners can use them to learn—but always test code.

8. Productivity AI

Examples: Notion AI, Grammarly, Motion, Fireflies.

Best for: Meeting notes, grammar, scheduling, knowledge bases.

9. Automation AI

Examples: Make, Zapier, n8n.

Best for: Connecting apps: “When X happens, do Y with AI in the middle.”

10. AI agents

Examples: OpenAI agent experiences, AutoGPT-style systems, custom agentic workflows.

Best for: Multi-step goals with tools. **Risk:** errors compound—start supervised.

Comparison at a glance

Category	Primary output	Start with	Pay when
Text LLM	Writing / reasoning	ChatGPT or Claude	Daily heavy use
Search AI	Cited answers	Perplexity	Research is your job
Docs research	Source-grounded notes	NotebookLM	Large private corpora
Images	Visuals	ChatGPT images or Flux	Brand/creative volume
Video	Clips	Runway or Veo access	Content team needs
Automation	Workflows	Zapier or Make	Repeatable processes

STARTER STACK (MOST PEOPLE)

ChatGPT or Claude (thinking/writing) + **Perplexity** (web research) + **NotebookLM** (your files) + one image tool. Add automation only after you repeat a task weekly.

Key Takeaways

- Match the tool category to the job—don't force ChatGPT to do everything.
- Search/research tools beat chatbots when citations and freshness matter.
- Automation pays off on repetition; agents need supervision.
- A small stack used deeply beats ten shallow subscriptions.

Action Steps

1. Write your top 10 recurring work tasks.
2. Label each with a tool category from this chapter.
3. Pick one gap and install only that missing tool this week.

PART 3

Mastering Essential AI Tools

These five tools cover most beginner-to-pro work: general LLMs, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity, and NotebookLM. Learn them once; transfer the skills forever.

Large Language Models

A Large Language Model (LLM) is an AI trained on vast text to predict and generate language. Chatbots are interfaces; the LLM is the engine underneath.

What an LLM is good at

- Drafting and editing text in many tones
- Brainstorming structures, options, and angles
- Explaining concepts at different levels
- Transforming formats (bullets → email → script)
- Light reasoning and planning (with oversight)

Major model families (2026 landscape)

Family	Maker	Standing strength
GPT	OpenAI	Generalist, tools, ecosystem, multimodal chat
Claude	Anthropic	Long context, careful writing, coding/analysis
Gemini	Google	Google Workspace + search ecosystem fit
DeepSeek	DeepSeek	Strong value / reasoning-oriented options
Llama	Meta	Open-weight ecosystem, local/self-host options
Mistral	Mistral	Efficient open/European-cloud oriented models

Model names and rankings change quickly. Judge by your tasks: writing quality, tool use, speed, price, privacy, and integrations.

Parameters, memory, reasoning, multimodality

- **Parameters:** Capacity of the model. Useful signal, not a scoreboard.
- **Chat memory:** Product feature that stores preferences across chats (optional).
- **Reasoning modes:** Some products spend more compute to plan before answering—better for hard problems, slower/costlier.
- **Multimodal:** Accepts or produces more than text (images, audio, files).

PRIVACY NOTE

Don't paste secrets, passwords, unpublished financials, or personal data of others into consumer AI tools unless your plan and policy explicitly allow it.

Choosing and switching LLMs like a pro

Beginners often ask, "Which model is best?" A better question is, "Which model is best for this job, with this data, at this budget?" Treat LLMs like specialists on a bench. One may be stronger at careful writing, another at fast brainstorming, another at coding, another at live web research, and another at multimodal understanding.

Need	Model habit to prefer	Switch when...
Polished writing	Give voice samples and ask for revisions	The output sounds generic after two critique passes
Analysis	Ask for assumptions, tradeoffs, and uncertainty	It ignores constraints or overstates confidence
Long documents	Use large context or Projects-style knowledge	It forgets earlier sections or invents details
Fresh facts	Use search or research tools with citations	Answers need current prices, dates, laws, or news
Images, files, audio	Use multimodal input directly	You are describing a file that you could simply upload

TIP

Run important prompts in two models, then ask a third pass: "Compare these two answers. Where do they disagree? Which parts are best supported?" This is cheaper than being confidently wrong.

When to switch models

- **After a clear failure:** If a model misunderstands the task twice, switch instead of endlessly rewording.
- **When the modality changes:** A text model may not be the best choice for screenshots, charts, invoices, or photos.
- **When stakes increase:** For legal, medical, financial, or public-facing work, use the model/tool with stronger grounding, citations, and review controls.

- **When speed matters:** Use smaller/faster models for extraction, tagging, rewriting, and drafts. Save premium models for judgment-heavy work.

Key Takeaways

- LLM = language engine; chatbot = product wrapper with tools and UI.
- Pick models by workflow fit, not hype cycles.
- Use specialized modes (search, reasoning, long context) when the task needs them.

CHAPTER 5

ChatGPT Complete Guide

ChatGPT is many beginners' first AI home base: conversation, drafting, analysis, images, voice, and custom tools in one place.

Getting started

1. Create an account at the official ChatGPT site.
2. Start on the free tier to learn; upgrade if you hit limits or need advanced models/features.
3. Set custom instructions: who you are, how you want answers (length, tone, format).

[Screenshot placeholder: ChatGPT home — new chat, model picker, sidebar]

Interface map

- **Sidebar:** past chats, projects, GPTs
- **Composer:** type prompts; attach files/images when available
- **Model picker:** choose speed vs. capability
- **Tools:** search, image generation, canvas/document editing, voice—depending on plan

Features that matter

Feature	Use it for
Projects	Group chats + files for one client or course
Memory	Remember preferences (review/delete regularly)
Canvas	Side-by-side editing of long docs/code
Search	Fresher answers with web context
Deep research	Broader multi-step research reports
Image generation	Concepts, thumbnails, simple marketing visuals
Voice mode	Hands-free brainstorming and tutoring
Custom GPTs	Reusable specialists with instructions + knowledge

Professional workflow

Client deliverable draft

Brief in Project → Outline → Draft sections → Critique pass → Final format

STRONG STARTER PROMPT

You are a senior marketing editor.
Goal: Write a landing-page hero section for a budgeting app for freelancers.
Audience: US freelancers, 25–40, overwhelmed by taxes.
Tone: Clear, confident, no hype.
Deliver: 1 headline, 1 subhead, 3 bullet benefits, 1 CTA.
Constraints: Max 60 characters for headline; avoid buzzwords like "revolutionary."

50 practical ChatGPT examples

1. Rewrite an email to be shorter and kinder
2. Turn meeting notes into action items with owners
3. Create a one-week meal plan from ingredients you have
4. Explain a PDF contract in plain language (then verify legally)
5. Generate interview questions for a role
6. Draft a LinkedIn post from a bullet list
7. Build a study plan for an exam date
8. Compare two product options in a table

9. Create a negotiation script for a raise
10. Summarize a YouTube transcript into takeaways
11. Produce SEO title options + meta description
12. Design a customer survey (10 questions)
13. Role-play an angry customer call
14. Convert a blog post into a Twitter/X thread
15. Create a project timeline from a vague goal
16. Draft a product requirements outline
17. Generate test cases from a feature description
18. Simplify a technical paragraph for executives
19. Create flashcards from lecture notes
20. Brainstorm brand name candidates + domains angle
21. Write a podcast show notes template
22. Produce a swipe file of ad hooks
23. Analyze a resume against a job description
24. Create a content calendar for 30 days
25. Draft SOPs from a messy process description
26. Generate SQL-like logic in plain English for non-coders
27. Plan a workshop agenda with timings
28. Create objection-handling scripts for sales
29. Turn analytics notes into an executive summary
30. Build a personal weekly review checklist
31. Rewrite a About page in three brand voices
32. Extract FAQs from a help-center dump
33. Create a competitive battlecard from notes
34. Draft a webinar landing page outline
35. Generate onboarding emails for a SaaS trial
36. Turn a spreadsheet description into chart recommendations
37. Create a risk list for a product launch
38. Draft a partnership outreach message
39. Build a glossary for a technical topic
40. Write alt text for a set of marketing images
41. Create a parenting / life admin weekly plan

12. Produce a travel itinerary with constraints
13. Draft a performance self-review from bullet wins
14. Generate lesson warm-up activities for teachers
15. Create a donation appeal for a nonprofit
16. Rewrite jargon-heavy policy into plain language
17. Plan an A/B test hypothesis list
18. Draft community moderation decision notes
19. Create a swipe file of subject lines for email
20. Build a personal knowledge capture template

COMMON MISTAKES

- One-shot vague prompts (“write a marketing plan”).
- Accepting citations without clicking them.
- Putting confidential data in chats.
- Never iterating—great output is usually draft 2–4.

Key Takeaways

- Custom instructions + Projects multiply consistency.
- Use search/research modes for time-sensitive facts.
- Custom GPTs encode repeatable expertise.
- Iterate: outline → draft → critique → polish.

Action Steps

1. Set custom instructions today (role, tone, format defaults).
2. Create one Project for your main work area and upload 2–3 reference files.
3. Save five prompts from this chapter into your AI Playbook.

CHAPTER 6

Claude Complete Guide

Claude (Anthropic) shines at long documents, careful analysis, thoughtful writing, and structured artifacts you can revise.

Strengths to exploit

- **Long context:** Large reports, book chapters, codebases summaries
- **Projects:** Persistent instructions + knowledge for a workspace
- **Artifacts:** Standalone documents, code, or mini-apps in a dedicated panel
- **Writing quality:** Strong editorial sense when guided

Writing workflow

Long-form article

Paste brief + sources → Ask for outline → Approve outline → Draft by section
→ Edit for voice

Project instructions: You are my editorial partner for practical how-to content.

Always: ask clarifying questions if the brief is ambiguous; prefer concrete examples; flag unsupported claims.

Audience default: smart beginners.

Research workflow

1. Upload PDFs or paste source notes.
2. Ask for a source map: themes, agreements, contradictions.
3. Request a brief with citations to your uploaded text (quotes + locations).
4. Generate the deliverable only after the brief is solid.

ARTIFACT USE CASE

Ask Claude to produce a one-page competitive teardown as an artifact, then: “Tighten to 400 words and add a decision table.” Iterate in place instead of re-pasting everything.

WHEN TO CHOOSE CLAUDE

Choose Claude when the input is long, the tone must feel human, or you need careful restructuring. Choose Search AI when you need live web citations first.

Claude Projects: practical setup

A Claude Project is most useful when it has a stable job. Instead of one giant "work" project, create focused spaces such as *Newsletter Editor*, *Client Proposal Assistant*, or *Support Policy Helper*. Add only the knowledge that should shape answers: voice guide, offer details, example work, policies, FAQs, and current constraints.

1. **Name the outcome:** "Draft client-ready proposals" beats "Marketing help."
2. **Add project instructions:** Role, audience, tone, forbidden claims, preferred format, and when to ask clarifying questions.
3. **Upload source material:** Keep it curated. Remove outdated docs so the assistant does not blend old and new facts.
4. **Save winning prompts:** Put your best repeat prompts in the Project notes or your AI Playbook.

ARTIFACTS EXAMPLES

- A one-page sales proposal that you can edit in the side panel.
- A simple landing page mockup in HTML.
- A comparison table for vendor selection.
- A checklist, rubric, or SOP your team can reuse.

Eight practical Claude prompts

Using the Project knowledge, draft a client proposal for [client]. Include problem, recommended plan, timeline, assumptions, and open questions. Do not invent pricing.

Turn this messy transcript into a clean SOP with owner, trigger, tools, steps, quality check, and escalation path.

Critique this draft against our voice guide. Return a table: issue, why it matters, suggested rewrite.

Create an Artifact: a one-page executive brief from these notes. Use headings, bullets, and a final recommendation.

Act as a skeptical customer. List the objections this landing page does not answer yet.

Summarize these sources into claims we can safely make, claims needing evidence, and claims to avoid.

Action Steps

1. Create a Claude Project with a one-paragraph house style.
2. Upload a 10+ page PDF and ask for a 1-page brief with quote-backed claims.
3. Produce one artifact (checklist or one-pager) for work this week.

CHAPTER 7

Gemini Complete Guide

Gemini is Google’s model family—most valuable when your work already lives in Gmail, Docs, Drive, and Workspace.

Why Gemini is different for beginners

Quality matters, but **distribution** matters more for daily habits. If AI appears beside the email you’re already writing, you will use it. Gemini’s edge is ecosystem gravity.

Practical Workspace patterns

App	High-value use
Gmail	Draft replies, shorten threads, extract action items
Docs	Outline, rewrite, summarize comments
Drive	Find themes across files; ask questions over documents you can access
Sheets	Explain formulas, generate analysis steps, clean column plans
Meet / notes	Summaries and follow-ups (where available)

From messy inbox to plan

Select thread → Summarize decisions → Draft reply → Create Docs action list
→ Schedule follow-ups

GROUNDING STILL REQUIRED

Workspace AI can misread a thread. For commitments, money, or legal wording, read the final text yourself.

Gemini inside Workspace: everyday workflows

Gemini becomes valuable when it works where your files already live. The trick is to use it for bounded tasks: summarize a thread, draft a Doc section, find patterns across notes, or turn a Drive folder into a briefing. Keep sensitive data rules in mind, especially in shared workspaces.

Gmail workflow: thread to decision

1. Open the thread and ask for the current decision, blockers, and people mentioned.
2. Ask Gemini to draft a reply with a specific tone and length.
3. Check names, dates, attachments, commitments, and quoted facts.
4. Send only after you personally approve the wording.

Docs workflow: rough notes to polished page

1. Paste messy notes into a Doc.
2. Ask for an outline first, not a full draft.
3. Approve the structure, then ask for one section at a time.
4. Use comments or suggestions for edits instead of overwriting important text.

Drive workflow: folder to brief

1. Collect the relevant Docs, Sheets, PDFs, and slides in one folder.
2. Ask for a source-aware summary: what is known, missing, and contradictory.
3. Ask for a deliverable such as an FAQ, project brief, or decision memo.

Workspace operating loop

Find source → Ask narrow question → Draft → Verify → Share

Six Gemini prompts

Summarize this Gmail thread into decisions, open questions, promised follow-ups, and risks. Quote the message date for each commitment.

Draft a 150-word reply that is friendly, clear, and action-oriented. Include two options for next steps.

Turn this Doc into an executive summary with: context, recommendation, tradeoffs, and next action.

Action Steps

1. Enable Gemini features available on your Google account/plan.
2. Pick one recurring email type and save a reply prompt template.
3. Run a Docs rewrite on a past report: clearer title, sharper exec summary, shorter paragraphs.

CHAPTER 8

Perplexity Complete Guide

Perplexity is an answer engine: question in, cited synthesis out. Use it when freshness and sources matter more than creative drafting.

Core habits

- Ask precise questions (“2025–2026”, “for freelancers in the EU”, “primary sources”).
- Open citations—don’t trust the summary alone.
- Use follow-ups to narrow: contradictions, costs, alternatives.
- Switch to deeper research modes for broader reports when available.

What are the main differences between Zapier, Make, and n8n for a 5-person marketing team in 2026?
Constraints: compare pricing model shape (not exact cents), learning curve, and best-fit use cases.
Output: table + recommendation. Prefer recent sources and cite them.

RESEARCH SANDWICH

Perplexity for sources → Claude/ChatGPT for structuring the narrative → human for conclusions and voice.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using Perplexity like a creative writer for brand storytelling. It’s a researcher first. Draft final copy in an LLM with your brand voice.

Deep research workflow

Perplexity is strongest when you treat research as a pipeline, not a single answer. Start broad, narrow the question, inspect sources, then synthesize. Your goal is not to collect links; it is to reach a defensible conclusion with citations you would be comfortable showing a manager or client.

1. **Frame the research question:** Include geography, date range, audience, and decision you need to make.
2. **Run a broad scan:** Ask for the landscape, major viewpoints, and key terms you should know.
3. **Open the sources:** Check publication date, author, original data, and whether the page actually supports the claim.
4. **Ask follow-ups:** Request counterarguments, recent changes, and primary sources.
5. **Export a brief:** Summary, evidence table, open questions, and recommendation.

CITATION HYGIENE

Prefer primary sources, official docs, peer-reviewed papers, government datasets, company filings, and reputable reporting. Do not cite a page just because it was returned. Click it, scan it, and confirm the cited line supports your statement.

Six research prompts

Research [topic] for a beginner business owner in [country]. Give the current landscape, important terms, top risks, and five sources worth reading.

Find recent data on [market]. Prefer primary sources. Return a table with claim, source, date, and confidence.

What are the strongest arguments for and against [decision]? Include citations for each side and note what evidence is missing.

Create a buyer's guide for [software category]. Compare pricing model, best-fit customer, limitations, and recent changes.

Build a timeline of major developments in [topic] over the last 24 months. Cite each milestone.

I need to brief my team on [issue]. Produce a one-page memo with recommendation, evidence, risks, and next questions.

Action Steps

1. Run three work questions you usually Google; save the best cited answer.
2. For one question, click every citation and rate trustworthiness.
3. Add a 'Research' section to your AI Playbook with source-check steps.

CHAPTER 9

NotebookLM Complete Guide

NotebookLM is Google's source-grounded research assistant. You upload materials; it answers from those sources—ideal for studying, briefings, and knowledge bases.

Core loop

NotebookLM loop

Create notebook → Add sources → Ask grounded questions →
Generate study guide / FAQ / briefing → Export insights to your docs

Source types that work well

- PDFs, docs, pasted notes, transcripts
- Policy manuals, sales decks, course readings
- Competitor pages saved as documents (respect copyright/ToS)

Business use cases

Role	Notebook idea
Founder	Investor Q&A notebook from pitch + financial narrative docs
Marketer	Brand voice + past campaigns → brief generator
Support lead	Help center + policies → answer drafts with citations
Student	Lecture PDFs → quizzes, timelines, podcast-style overviews
Consultant	Client discovery notes → structured proposal outline

PODCAST / AUDIO OVERVIEW

Where available, NotebookLM can generate an audio overview of your sources—useful for commuting revision. Treat it as a study aid, not a citable academic authority.

QUALITY RULE

Garbage sources → garbage notebooks. Curate. Split sprawling topics into multiple notebooks.

NotebookLM business playbooks

NotebookLM is best when you want answers grounded in your own material. Think of each notebook as a mini knowledge base for one job: onboarding, policies, product research, sales enablement, grant writing, or course creation. The quality of the notebook depends less on the AI and more on the sources you choose.

Source curation rules

- **Use authoritative files:** final policies, current product docs, approved messaging, transcripts, contracts you are allowed to analyze, and research PDFs.
- **Remove stale material:** If old pricing or policies remain, NotebookLM may blend them with current facts.
- **Name sources clearly:** "2026 Pricing FAQ" is better than "final_v3_reallyfinal.pdf."
- **Ask source-specific questions:** "According to the onboarding guide..." keeps answers grounded.

FIVE DETAILED USE CASES

1. **Support policy desk:** Upload refund rules, warranty terms, escalation SOPs, and macros. Ask for draft replies with cited policy sections.
2. **Sales battlecard:** Add competitor notes, product docs, objections, and case studies. Generate talk tracks and objection responses.
3. **Employee onboarding:** Upload handbook, benefits guide, org chart, and role SOPs. Create a first-week FAQ and quiz.
4. **Course builder:** Add lesson transcripts, readings, and worksheets. Generate study guides, flashcards, and module summaries.
5. **Research room:** Add reports and interviews. Ask for themes, contradictions, evidence tables, and open questions.

Study guide and podcast tips

The study guide is great for turning dense sources into a learning path. Use it, then ask follow-up questions about weak areas. Audio overviews are useful for first exposure, commute review, or stakeholder previews, but they should not replace reading the cited sections for high-stakes work.

Action Steps

1. Create one notebook with 3–5 high-quality sources for a live project.
2. Generate a FAQ and a one-page briefing.
3. Ask: “What do my sources not cover that I still need?”

PART 4

Prompt Engineering

Prompting is the universal skill. Same model, different prompt—completely different results. This part turns vague chatting into professional direction.

Prompt Engineering Foundations

A prompt is the full instruction you give an AI: task, context, constraints, and desired format. Clear prompts produce clear work.

Why prompts matter

Models are general. Your prompt narrows the universe of possible answers. Professionals don't "ask AI"—they brief it like a talented junior contractor.

Components of a strong prompt

1. **Role:** who the AI should act as
2. **Goal:** what done looks like
3. **Audience:** who will read/use the output
4. **Context:** facts, product, constraints, examples
5. **Process:** steps (outline first, then draft)
6. **Format:** table, bullets, email, JSON, script
7. **Quality bar:** tone, length, must-include / must-avoid

WEAK VS STRONG

Weak: "Write a business plan."

Strong: "Act as an SMB consultant. Create a 1-page lean plan for a home organizing service in Austin targeting busy parents. Include problem, offer, pricing hypothesis, 3 channels, 90-day milestones. No fluff. Table for milestones."

Iteration pattern

Pro iteration

Brief → Outline → Draft → Critique → Tighten → Final

Ask the model to critique its own draft against your checklist. Then apply fixes.

The five components of a strong prompt

A prompt is a brief. Good briefs reduce guessing. Most beginner prompts fail because they include a task but omit context, audience, constraints, source material, and output format.

Component	What it answers	Example
Role	Who should the AI act like?	Act as a practical small-business CFO.
Task	What should it produce?	Create a cash-flow checklist.
Context	What background matters?	Audience: first-time agency owner.
Constraints	What boundaries apply?	No jargon; max 12 items; flag risks.
Format	How should output look?	Table with priority, action, and why.

Before and after

BEFORE

"Write a marketing plan for my bakery."

AFTER

Act as a local business marketing strategist. Create a 30-day marketing plan for a neighborhood sourdough bakery in Austin. Goal: increase weekday morning foot traffic. Budget: \$500. Audience: office workers within 2 miles. Include daily actions, low-cost partnership ideas, email/social copy themes, and how to measure success. Table format.

The second prompt gives the model something to optimize. It can now make tradeoffs instead of writing generic advice.

Temperature and style intuition

If a tool exposes temperature or creativity settings, think of it as a "variation dial." Low settings are better for extraction, summaries, policy replies, and structured outputs. Higher settings are useful for names, hooks, concepts, and brainstorming. If the tool does not expose temperature, you can still steer style with words such as "literal," "conservative," "playful," "unexpected," or "executive."

Key Takeaways

- Prompts are briefs, not magic words.
- Format instructions dramatically improve usability.
- Iteration beats one giant mega-prompt for complex work.

CHAPTER 11

Prompt Frameworks

Frameworks are training wheels that become instincts. Memorize a few; remix freely.

RTF — Role, Task, Format

Role: Career coach for career-switchers into UX.
Task: Create a 30-day learning plan.
Format: Week-by-week table with daily time estimates and deliverables.

CRISPE

Capacity/Role · Request · Insight/Context · Statement of goal · Personality/Tone · Experiment/Evaluate

Capacity: Senior B2B SaaS copywriter.
Request: Rewrite this homepage H1/H2.
Insight: Users fear complex setup; we offer 2-day onboarding.
Goal: Increase demo clicks.
Personality: Plain-spoken, confident, specific.
Evaluate: Give 3 variants and predict which converts best and why.

APE — Action, Purpose, Expectation

Action: Summarize the transcript.
Purpose: Prep me for a 10-minute exec update.
Expectation: 5 bullets max, each with a decision needed.

Chain of Thought (ask for steps)

For logic, math, or tradeoffs: “Think step by step. List assumptions. Then conclude.”

Tree of Thoughts

Ask for 2–3 distinct approaches, evaluate each, then pick/merge a winner. Great for strategy and creative direction.

Few-shot prompting

Provide 2–3 examples of ideal input → output, then the new input. Best for consistent tone and structure.

FRAMEWORK PICKER

RTF for speed · CRISPE for marketing · Few-shot for voice matching · Tree of Thoughts for strategy · CoT for analysis.

EXERCISE — UPGRADE A PROMPT

Take a vague prompt you used this month. Rewrite it with RTF and again with CRISPE. Compare outputs side by side.

CHAPTER 12

Professional Prompt Library

Copy, adapt, reuse. Replace bracketed fields. Keep winners in your AI Playbook.

Marketing (12)

Write 10 ad hooks for [product] targeting [audience]. Pain-focused, under 12 words each.

Create a customer persona for [offer] with goals, fears, objections, and waterhole channels.

Turn these features into benefits: [list]. Audience: [who]. Table format.

Draft a launch email sequence (3 emails) for [product]. Goal: [trial/demo].

Build a positioning statement: For [audience] who [problem], [brand] is [category] that [benefit]. Unlike [alt], we [difference].

Generate 15 YouTube titles for [topic]—curiosity + clarity, no clickbait lies.

Create a landing page outline with section goals and primary CTA.

Write 5 retargeting ads based on objection: [objection].

Produce a competitor teardown template, then fill it for [competitor] using provided notes.

Suggest a 30-day content calendar for [brand] across LinkedIn + email.

Rewrite this copy at an 8th-grade reading level without losing meaning: [paste].

Give me a SWOT from these notes: [paste]. Be blunt.

Sales (8)

Create a discovery-call script for [service] with qualifying questions and disqualifiers.

Write objection responses for: price, timing, need to ask partner, already have vendor.

Summarize this call transcript into next steps, risks, and a follow-up email.

Draft a proposal one-pager from these notes: [paste].

Role-play as a skeptical buyer. Interview me about [offer].

Write a breakup email for stalled deals—polite, short, with an easy yes.

Create a CRM note template fields for [sales motion].

Map a 5-email nurture for cold leads interested in [topic].

Content & social (10)

Turn this outline into a 1,000-word blog post with examples and a checklist ending: [outline].

Create a carousel outline (8 slides) teaching [topic].

Repurpose this article into: LinkedIn post, X thread, newsletter blurb, short video script.

Write 20 scroll-stopping first lines about [theme].

Generate a content series plan: 6 parts, escalating difficulty.

Create a brand voice chart: words we use / words we avoid for [brand].

Draft community guidelines FAQ in friendly tone.

Write a podcast episode outline with timestamps goals for [topic].

Create thumbnail text options (3–4 words) for [video idea].

Give me a hook-body-CTA template pack for short video.

Business & ops (10)

Draft an SOP for [process] with owner, trigger, steps, QA check, tools.

Turn these messy notes into a decision log: [paste].

Create a hiring scorecard for [role].

Write a project kickoff agenda (45 min).

Build a risk register from this plan: [paste].

Draft a vendor evaluation rubric for [category].

Create a weekly KPI review template for a small team.

Write a customer apology email for [incident]—accountable, specific, no legalese fog.

Generate onboarding checklist for new contractors.

Summarize this policy into a 10-bullet employee cheat sheet: [paste].

Education & research (8)

Explain [concept] three ways: analogy, steps, common mistakes.

Create a quiz (10 questions) from these notes with an answer key: [paste].

Make a study schedule for [exam] on [date] with weak-area emphasis.

Compare theories A and B in a table with practical implications.

Extract definitions and key claims from this text; flag unsupported leaps.

Create a lesson plan for 60 minutes on [topic] for beginners.

Socratic tutor me on [topic]; ask one question at a time.

Produce an annotated bibliography style summary from these abstracts: [paste].

Programming / technical (for beginners) (8)

Explain this error like I'm new, then give fix steps: [error].

Write pseudocode for [automation idea] before any real code.

Review this script for security/privacy issues: [paste].

Create a test plan for [feature].

Translate this requirement into user stories + acceptance criteria.

Suggest a simple architecture for [app idea] using no-code where possible.

Document this function in plain language: [paste].

Give a debugging checklist for [symptom].

That's 56 ready prompts spanning the major work domains—extend each with your brand facts and examples (few-shot) for production quality.

Action Steps

1. Copy 15 prompts into your AI Playbook and fill brackets for your business.
2. Create one few-shot block with 3 samples of your best writing.
3. Run the same task with RTF and CRISPE; keep the better pattern.

PART 5

AI Image Generation

Images are now a language. Learn how diffusion models work at a practical level, then learn the prompt grammar that art directors use.

Introduction to AI Images

Image models generate pictures from noise by gradually shaping random pixels toward your prompt. You steer with language—and increasingly with reference images.

Diffusion in plain English

Imagine reverse-blurring a messy TV signal until a clear photo appears—guided by your words. That’s the intuition behind diffusion models.

Prompt structure that works

- 1. **Subject:** who/what
- 2. **Action / pose:** what’s happening
- 3. **Setting:** where / time
- 4. **Style:** photo, illustration, 3D, clay, editorial...
- 5. **Lighting & camera:** softbox, golden hour, 35mm, top-down...
- 6. **Quality cues:** composition, texture, color grade
- 7. **Negatives:** what to avoid (when the tool supports it)

Tool	Best known for
Midjourney	Aesthetic, artistic look
Flux	Strong realism / controllable generation
DALL·E (in ChatGPT)	Convenience + iterative chat edits
Ideogram	Text in images
Leonardo	Design workflows & resources

RIGHTS & ETHICS

Avoid impersonating real private people, copying living artists’ names as a shortcut, and using generated marks that confuse brands. Check each tool’s commercial license.

Image Prompt Engineering

Camera language upgrades results faster than adjective spam. Direct the shot like a brief to a photographer.

Useful camera & light vocabulary

- **Angles:** eye-level, low angle, bird's-eye, over-the-shoulder, Dutch angle
- **Lenses:** 24mm environment, 35mm documentary, 85mm portrait, macro
- **Light:** soft window light, hard noon sun, rim light, neon glow, overcast flat
- **Film/grade:** Kodak Portra vibe, teal-orange grade, matte documentary

Character consistency tips

- Lock a written character sheet (age, face shape, hair, wardrobe).
- Use reference images / character features when the tool allows.
- Change one variable per revision (pose OR scene OR style).

80 image prompt starters

Copy and customize. Each line is a complete starter brief.

1. Product photo of matte black water bottle on travertine, soft window light, 45° angle, subtle condensation, high-end catalog style
2. Overhead flat lay of freelancer desk: laptop, notebook, coffee, plant, natural daylight, neat composition
3. Founder portrait, 85mm, shallow depth of field, warm indoor ambient + soft key, confident smile, blurred office
4. Isometric 3D illustration of tiny bakery shopfront, pastel clay materials, soft shadows
5. Editorial photo of rainy Tokyo street at night, neon reflections, cinematic widescreen
6. Kids' picture-book illustration of a friendly fox reading a map, watercolor textures, cream paper
7. UI mockup poster: fitness app dashboard on iPhone, soft gradient backdrop, clean modern marketing style
8. Food photography: rustic sourdough loaf torn open, crumb detail, side light, dark moody backdrop
9. Architecture exterior of small coastal cabin, dawn fog, 24mm, documentary realism
10. Infographic-style illustration of AI workflow nodes connected by lines, minimal vector, teal accents on off-white

1. Fashion lookbook shot, linen summer set, wind movement, golden hour beach path
2. Macro photo of mechanical watch gears, specular highlights, black background
3. Storyboard frame: courier handing package to customer, warm porch light, naturalistic
4. Surreal collage poster: floating library rooms above a calm sea, paper-cut style
5. Black-and-white street photo, decisive moment at crosswalk, high contrast
6. 3D render of eco detergent bottle, studio softbox, soft reflection on floor, commercial packshot
7. Hand-drawn chalkboard menu style listing coffee drinks, charming imperfect lettering
8. Fantasy concept art: mossy temple gate, volumetric god rays, wide establishing shot
9. Medical explainer illustration of heart cross-section, clean textbook style, labeled areas blank
10. Cozy café interior, morning light through blinds, empty table near window, lifestyle magazine
11. Robot assistant gently watering plants in a home, friendly design, soft daylight, photoreal
12. Vintage travel poster of Lisbon tram, limited color palette, mid-century graphic style
13. YouTube thumbnail concept: shocked creator pointing at laptop chart, bold simple background, space for title text
14. Transparent glass perfume bottle with botanical shadows, bright high-key studio
15. Low-poly game art of mountain campsite at dusk
16. Documentary portrait of artisan potter at wheel, dusty workshop, available light
17. Abstract brand background: soft mesh gradients, grain, ample negative space for typography
18. Kids STEM kit unboxing hero shot, bright even light, colorful components arranged neatly
19. Cybersecurity concept: lock made of circuit traces, dark blue technical illustration
20. Wedding invitation floral border, elegant line art, generous blank center
21. Sports action still: amateur runner mid-stride, panning blur background, dawn road
22. Interior design viz: small apartment living room, Scandinavian oak + olive textiles, photoreal
23. Comic panel, 3-frame sequence of a barista learning an AI POS, clean ink, soft flat colors
24. Satellite-style map illustration of a fictional walkable town, pastel legend-ready
25. Luxury chocolate bar break reveal, shards and cocoa dust, dramatic side light
26. Classroom scene redesign: collaborative tables, plants, natural light, architectural sketch overlay
27. Podcast cover art: two hosts as bold vector portraits, limited palette, headphone motif
28. Before/after cleaning service photo style: split composition of same kitchen, realistic
29. Soft ceramic mug mockup floating on pastel backdrop for Shopify listing
30. Cinematic still: solitary lighthouse, stormy sea, anamorphic lens flares subtle, film still
31. Soft morning skincare shelfie, bathroom marble, gentle steam, lifestyle beauty ad

12. Exploded-view illustration of a mechanical pencil, technical blueprint aesthetic
13. Crowdfunding campaign hero: diverse makers around a workbench prototype, hopeful daylight
14. Minimal logo mockup on craft paper bag, brand identity presentation style
15. Night desk setup with dual monitors coding, practical RGB muted, cozy productivity mood
16. Farm-to-table vegetable crate, outdoor market, crisp daylight, editorial food story
17. App onboarding illustration set: three panels showing problem → tool → result, friendly flat design
18. Historical museum exhibit photo style of ancient pottery, soft spotlight, dark gallery
19. Electric bike on city street, motion blur background, lifestyle campaign, golden hour
20. Handwritten journal open on linen, pen beside, soft top-down light, calm productivity aesthetic
21. Paper craft diorama of a tiny office, miniature clay characters collaborating
22. Glossy magazine cover mockup with bold typography space, fashion-tech theme
23. Scientist and student collaborating at lab bench, hopeful documentary lighting
24. Reusable packaging design flat lay: box, tissue, sticker, thank-you card
25. Snowy cabin window view with steam mug foreground, cozy travel editorial
26. Isometric map of online course journey milestones, clean infographic
27. Vintage camera on wooden table, side window light, product lifestyle
28. Community garden volunteers planting seedlings, authentic candid photo style
29. Futuristic but grounded clinic reception, soft greens, human-centered design viz
30. Stack of color-coded notebooks, overhead, stationery brand catalog
31. Child building with blocks, shallow DOF, warm home interior, parenting brand
32. Open laptop showing analytics dashboard, coffee and plant, creator workspace
33. Hand-sewn leather wallet detail macro, artisan brand story
34. City coworking space wide shot, natural light, inclusive modern workplace
35. Illustrated recipe card layout with blank text areas, watercolor ingredients
36. Drone-style still of coastal boardwalk, late afternoon haze, travel brochure
37. Security professional reviewing wall of monitors, restrained cinematic teal grade
38. Elegant dining table setting for two, candlelight, restaurant marketing
39. Retro pixel-art scene of a tiny library interior
40. Medical wearable on wrist, clean white product studio, clinical trustworthy
41. Teachers' lounge brainstorm wall with sticky notes, documentary candid
42. Sustainable fashion rack of linen garments, airy boutique interior
43. Board game night flat lay, colorful pieces, inviting social photo

- '4. Architect model of courtyard housing, soft studio light, design presentation
- '5. Close-up of violin bowing, concert hall bokeh, cultural arts poster
- '6. Emergency go-bag contents organized on tarp, practical preparedness guide visual
- '7. Soft clay character mascot waving, brand IP concept, studio softbox
- '8. Rainy bus window portrait, reflective mood, indie film still
- '9. Hydroponic indoor farm rows, clean tech-ag aesthetic, bright even light
- '10. Thank-you card mockup with botanical border and empty center for message

Action Steps

1. Build a one-page style card for your brand (palette, lighting, do/don't).
2. Generate the same subject in three styles; pick a house style.
3. Save 10 winning prompts with the image filenames in your Playbook.

PART 6

AI Video Generation

Video models turn prompts—or still images—into motion. Treat them as pre-visualization and short-form engines, not overnight Hollywood.

Video AI Fundamentals

Three input modes dominate: text-to-video, image-to-video, and video-to-video (restyle/extend). Pick based on control needs.

Mode	You provide	Best when
Text → video	Prompt only	Ideation, b-roll concepts
Image → video	Key still + motion brief	You need visual consistency
Video → video	Source clip	Style transfer, variations

Plan shots short (2–8 seconds). Write prompts like shot lists: subject, camera move, lighting, lens, pacing.

PRODUCTION TIP

Generate multiple takes, pick the best seconds, and edit traditionally. Hybrid workflows beat one-shot perfect clips.

Think in shots, not scenes

Video AI works best when you ask for one clear shot at a time. A "scene" may include multiple camera angles, actions, and timing changes. A "shot" is simpler: one subject, one action, one camera move, one mood. If you need a 30-second ad, plan it as five or six short clips and edit them together.

Shot type	What it does	Prompt cue
Establishing	Shows place and context	wide shot of...
Medium	Shows person and action	medium shot, waist up...
Close-up	Shows detail or emotion	macro close-up of hands...
Over-the-shoulder	Shows a screen or conversation	over the shoulder, laptop visible...
Product hero	Makes an object feel premium	slow push-in, studio lighting...

Aspect ratios

- **16:9:** YouTube, websites, presentations, horizontal ads.
- **9:16:** TikTok, Reels, Shorts, mobile-first stories.
- **1:1:** Feed posts, simple product loops, flexible social assets.

- **4:5:** Social feed ads where vertical space matters.

LIMITATIONS

Video models still struggle with exact text, consistent faces across many shots, complex physics, precise product labels, and long cause-and-effect sequences. Generate short clips, then use normal editing tools for timing, captions, logos, and audio.

CHAPTER 16

Veo Guide

Google Veo is a leading text/image-to-video model family. Prompt with cinematic language—camera, lens, motion, continuity.

Prompt pattern

Shot type + subject + action + environment + camera movement + lighting + style + duration cue.

Example: "Medium shot of a ceramicist shaping clay on a wheel, slow dolly-in, soft morning window light, shallow depth of field, naturalistic documentary, subtle hand motion, 5 seconds."

Camera moves that read clearly

- Static tripod · slow push-in · pull-out · pan · tilt · orbit · tracking sideways · handheld subtle

40 Veo-ready examples

1. Product hero: bottle rotates on seamless infinity curve, soft studio lights, macro label detail
2. Founder walks through bright studio, steadicam follow, candid confidence
3. Coffee pour macro, steam rising, slow motion, warm café bokeh
4. City dawn timelapse feel from rooftop, gentle pan across skyline
5. Hands unboxing eco sneakers, top-down, crisp e-commerce lighting
6. Teacher explains on whiteboard, locked-off camera, friendly classroom
7. Drone-like rise over coastal path (keep motion physically plausible)
8. Night market stalls, handheld wander, neon reflections on wet pavement
9. Yoga flow silhouette at sunrise, side profile, calm pace
0. Keyboard typing close-up for SaaS b-roll, shallow DOF
1. Pet running through park toward camera, joyful, sunny

2. Architect reviews blueprint on large table, overhead slow orbit
3. EV charging at modern station, dusk, cinematic teal shadows
4. Bread scoring and oven spring, rustic bakery documentary
5. UI screen recording style recreation: cursor clicks through clean dashboard (abstracted)
6. Rain on window with cozy room interior soft focus beyond
7. Warehouse picker with handheld scanner, authentic logistics feel
8. Kids STEM experiment volcano, playful, safe classroom energy
9. Tailor pins a suit jacket, intimate workshop lamp light
10. Farmers market vendor hands customer berries, warm sincerity
11. Abstract particles forming a logo morph (keep simple geometry)
12. Train window landscape sliding by, reflective mood
13. Lab scientist pipettes sample, clinical bright lighting
14. Street mural artist time-compressed painting strokes
15. Quiet library aisle push-in toward sunlit desk
16. Slow orbit around handmade ceramic bowl set, soft daylight studio
17. Runner ties shoes at dawn trailhead, handheld intimate framing
18. Chef plates pasta with tweezers, shallow DOF, restaurant kitchen glow
19. Child's hands planting a seed in soil, gentle educational tone
10. Courier bike weaving carefully through quiet morning streets
11. Open laptop on airplane tray, clouds beyond window, travel work mood
12. Jewelry clasp close-up as necklace is fastened, luxury ad pacing
13. Community volunteers painting a fence, documentary sunny afternoon
14. Smart home thermostat interaction, clean modern interior, subtle push-in
15. Bookstore aisle browse, warm practical light, cozy commerce feel
16. Mechanic lowers EV hood, competent craftsmanship, natural garage light
17. Waves wash over rocky shore, static tripod, meditative brand b-roll
18. Makeup brush applies foundation, beauty macro, soft ring light
19. Team huddle around whiteboard then disperse to desks, office energy
10. Candle being lit in calm living room, slow and intimate evening mood

Action Steps

1. Storyboard a 15-second ad as 3 shots.
2. Generate each shot separately.
3. Edit together with captions in a normal editor.

CHAPTER 17

Runway, Kling, Pika and Sora

Tool	Strengths	Watch-outs	Use when
Runway	Creator suite, editing + gen tools	Credits; learning surface	Creative teams iterating clips
Kling	Strong motion / cinematic clips	Access & policy vary	Ambitious motion shots
Pika	Fast social-style generation	Fine control limits	Quick ideation & memes-to-motion
Sora	High-end OpenAI video generation	Availability/limits	Premium text/image-to-video needs
Veo	Google ecosystem video model	Access via Google products	Cinematic prompting + Google stack

SELECTION RULE

Pick the tool you can actually access reliably, then master shot language. Prompt craft transfers; brand lock-in doesn't have to.

PART 7

AI Audio Generation

Voice and music tools finish the content stack: narration, podcasts, explainers, and placeholder scores.

Voice AI

Modern speech synthesis turns text into natural voiceovers. ElevenLabs and PlayHT are popular starting points.

Workflow

Voiceover

Write script → Mark pauses → Choose voice → Generate →
Edit breaths/timing → Mix under video

- Write for the ear: shorter sentences, phonetic clarity, pronounceability.
- Add stage directions sparingly (“pause”, “warmer”).
- Keep a voice bible: voice ID, speed, stability settings.

CONSENT & CLONING

Only clone voices you have rights and consent to use. Disclose synthetic voice when required by platform or law.

Script a 60-second product explainer for [product]. Friendly expert tone. Mark [PAUSE] where needed. Max 140 words.

Music AI

Suno and Udio generate songs from text prompts—useful for drafts, social beds, and creative exploration.

Upbeat indie-pop, 100 BPM, warm female vocals, song about learning AI without fear, clear chorus, radio-clean, no explicit content.

- Specify genre, tempo, mood, instruments, vocal type, and structure cues.
- Generate variants; treat outputs as drafts for licensing review.
- For client work, confirm commercial terms before publishing.

PRACTICAL USE

Use AI music for animatics and social tests; hire composers when brand identity and exclusivity matter.

PART 8

AI Productivity

The highest ROI is often boring: email, meetings, notes, and follow-ups. Make AI your operations intern.

Personal Productivity with AI

Meetings

Record/transcribe (with permission) → summarize decisions, owners, deadlines → draft follow-up email.

From this transcript, produce: (1) 5-bullet summary, (2) decisions, (3) action table with owner + due date, (4) open questions. Flag anything unclear.

Email

- Paste the thread; ask for intent + draft reply options (short / detailed).
- Keep a tone pack: firm, warm, formal.

Research & learning

Learn a topic

Perplexity scan → Save best sources → NotebookLM notebook →
Teach-back to ChatGPT → 1-page cheat sheet

Writing

Outline with AI, draft yourself or co-draft, then ask for a critique against a checklist (clarity, specificity, claims).

Key Takeaways

- Permission first on recordings.
- Summaries are drafts until you confirm owners/dates.
- Teach-back reveals what you didn't learn.

Business Productivity

Function	AI workflow
Marketing	Brief → variants → critique → brand edit → schedule
Support	Policy notebook → draft reply → human send for edge cases
Sales	Call notes → CRM summary → personalized follow-up
HR	Scorecards, JD drafts, onboarding checklists (watch bias)
Operations	SOP drafting, incident timelines, vendor comparisons

BUSINESS FAILURE MODE

Publishing unedited AI text that sounds generic—or worse, wrong—damages trust. AI accelerates drafts; humans own outcomes.

Action Steps

1. Pick one function above.
2. Document a 5-step AI workflow.
3. Run it for five real cases this week.

PART 9

AI Automation

Automation connects apps so work happens without copy-paste. AI sits in the middle to classify, draft, or decide within guardrails.

Automation Fundamentals

Every automation is: **Trigger** → (optional filters) → **Actions**. AI actions transform messy text into structured fields.

- **Trigger:** new email, form submit, schedule, webhook
- **Action:** create task, send Slack, draft reply, update Sheet
- **API:** how apps talk; no-code tools hide most of this

AUTOMATION FITNESS TEST

Automate if you do it ≥3×/week, rules are clear, and mistakes are reversible or reviewed.

GUARDRAILS

Start with drafts + human approval for anything external (customer email, social posts, payments).

Triggers, actions, and AI in the middle

An automation begins when a trigger happens: a form is submitted, an email is labeled, a row is added, a date arrives, or a webhook receives data. Actions do the work: create a task, send a message, update a CRM, draft an email, or write a file. AI is most useful in the middle, where messy human language must become structured decisions.

AI-in-the-middle pattern	Example	Guardrail
Classify	Tag support email as billing, bug, refund, or urgent.	Escalate if confidence is low.
Extract	Pull name, company, budget, and deadline from a form.	Validate required fields before writing.
Draft	Create a reply, proposal, or social post.	Save as draft for approval.
Summarize	Turn a call transcript into CRM notes.	Link back to transcript.
Route	Send leads to the right salesperson.	Log the reason for routing.

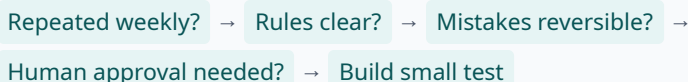
Failure modes to expect

- Bad trigger data: missing fields, duplicate records, or unexpected file types.

- Overconfident AI: the model guesses instead of saying it does not know.
- Silent breakage: an app permission expires and the workflow stops.
- Runaway volume: a loop creates hundreds of tasks or messages.
- No owner: everyone assumes the automation is being monitored.

Decision tree

Should you automate?



CHAPTER 23

n8n Complete Guide

n8n is a flexible workflow automation tool, popular for builders who want control (self-host or cloud).

Setup (conceptual)

1. Choose cloud or self-hosted install.
2. Connect credentials (OpenAI/Anthropic, Gmail, Slack, Sheets...).
3. Build node-by-node; test with sample data.

10 workflow blueprints

1. Form → AI enrich lead → CRM row → Slack alert
2. Support email → AI classify urgency → route mailbox/ticket
3. RSS → AI summarize → newsletter draft Doc
4. New Drive file → transcript/summary → Notion page
5. Schedule: weekly metrics Sheet → AI narrative → email report
6. Typeform feedback → sentiment tag → dashboard Sheet
7. Twitter/X mention monitor → draft response queue
8. Inbound invoice PDF → extract fields → accounting Sheet (review)
9. Calendar end event → AI meeting notes template → task list
10. Webhook from store → AI product blurb → Shopify draft (approval)

n8n AI node pattern

Trigger → Normalize text → LLM extract JSON → Validate fields →
Write to app → Notify

CHAPTER 24

Make Complete Guide

Make (formerly Integromat) uses visual scenarios and modules—strong for marketers and ops teams.

10 Make scenarios

1. Facebook Lead Ad → AI score → HubSpot + email nurture start
2. Google Form job application → AI screen vs scorecard → Sheets + recruiter ping
3. Instagram DM keyword → FAQ reply draft
4. Shopify order → personalized thank-you email draft
5. Intercom chat ended → summary to Notion QA log
6. YouTube upload → AI chapters + description draft → notify editor
7. Expense email receipt → extract → bookkeeping Sheet
8. Webinar signup → AI segment → tailored sequence
9. CSAT low score → create Zendesk ticket with context brief
10. Content calendar row status=ready → generate social variants pack

MAKE TIP

Use routers and filters early. Keep AI modules deterministic with JSON schemas / strict formats.

CHAPTER 25

Zapier Complete Guide

Zapier is the friendliest entry point: Zaps connect thousands of apps quickly.

10 Zaps to build

1. Gmail labeled “Speak” → AI draft reply → save to Drafts
2. New Calendar event → prep brief from linked Doc

3. Typeform → AI summary → Slack channel
4. RSS → AI hook options → Buffer draft
5. New CRM deal stage → generate kickoff checklist tasks
6. Zoom recording ready → transcript summary → email attendees
7. Airtable content idea → AI outline → Docs
8. Shopify new product → AI SEO title/meta suggestions
9. Help Scout tag “refund” → policy-aware draft (approval)
10. Daily schedule Zap → AI prioritize task list from Todoist

Action Steps

1. Build one Zap with a human approval step.
2. Log failures for a week; tighten filters.
3. Document the Zap in your Playbook.

PART 10

AI Agents

Agents don't just answer—they plan and use tools toward a goal. Powerful, but they need boundaries.

Understanding AI Agents

An AI agent is a system that can set subgoals, call tools (browse, code, email, databases), remember state, and iterate until a stop condition.

Architecture (beginner map)

- **Brain:** LLM for planning and language
- **Tools:** actions it may take
- **Memory:** short-term thread + optional long-term store
- **Planner:** break goal → steps → revisit
- **Guardrails:** permissions, budgets, human approval

REALITY CHECK

Unsupervised agents can loop, spend money, or message customers incorrectly. Start read-only or draft-only.

Agent architecture by analogy

Imagine hiring an intern for a specific job. The LLM is the intern's reasoning and communication ability. Tools are what the intern is allowed to use: browser, email, calendar, database, spreadsheet, code runner, or CRM. Memory is the notebook they keep. Planning is the habit of breaking a goal into steps. Guardrails are the manager's rules: budget, permissions, review points, and when to stop.

Agent part	Beginner analogy	Example
Goal	The assignment	Prepare a weekly competitor brief.
Tools	Allowed apps	Search web, read Drive folder, create Doc.
Memory	Working notes	Previous competitor list and style preferences.
Planner	To-do list	Find sources, extract claims, compare, draft.
Evaluator	Quality check	Are all claims cited? Is the brief under one page?

Tools, memory, and planning examples

- **Tool example:** A support agent can read a policy notebook and draft replies, but cannot issue refunds without approval.

- **Memory example:** A personal planning agent remembers your preferred working hours and recurring goals, but not private data it does not need.
- **Planning example:** A research agent first lists questions, then searches, then writes a source table, then drafts a memo.

RISKS

- **Compounding errors:** One bad assumption can affect many later actions.
- **Tool misuse:** The agent may update the wrong record or message the wrong person.
- **Runaway loops:** Poor stop conditions can waste time, credits, or API calls.
- **Data exposure:** Broad permissions create bigger privacy risk.

CHAPTER 27

Building Agent Workflows

Practical examples

- **Research agent:** gather sources → outline → brief (human publishes)
- **Support agent:** retrieve policy → draft → escalate if confidence low
- **Marketing agent:** pull product facts → generate campaign pack → Slack approval

BUSINESS PATTERN

Goal: “Prepare a weekly competitor brief.” Tools: web fetch, Drive write, email. Stop when a 1-page Doc exists. Human reviews every Friday.

Safe agent loop

Define goal → Limit tools → Require approval gates → Log actions → Review weekly

Five agent workflow specs

1. Marketing campaign assistant

Goal: create a campaign draft pack from approved product facts. **Tools:** brand docs, product page, calendar, Doc creation. **Output:** audience, hooks, email draft, social variants, review checklist. **Approval:** marketer approves before publishing.

2. Support response assistant

Goal: reduce first-response time. **Tools:** policy notebook, ticket system, macro library. **Output:** category, urgency, draft reply, cited policy. **Escalate:** angry customers, refunds, legal threats, safety issues, low confidence.

3. Research briefing agent

Goal: prepare a weekly brief on a defined topic. **Tools:** web search, saved source list, Docs. **Output:** source table, key changes, risks, recommendation. **Rule:** no uncited factual claims.

4. Operations SOP agent

Goal: turn transcripts and notes into standard operating procedures. **Tools:** transcript folder, SOP template, task manager. **Output:** SOP draft, checklist, missing questions. **Approval:** process owner signs off.

5. Personal weekly planning agent

Goal: convert calendar, tasks, and goals into a realistic week plan. **Tools:** calendar read access, task list, notes. **Output:** top outcomes, schedule blocks, risks, prep list. **Limit:** read-only until trusted.

Action Steps

1. Write an agent spec: goal, tools, data access, success metric, kill switch.
2. Implement as a Make/n8n flow before full autonomy.

PART 11

Real-World Projects

Theory sticks when you ship. Twenty complete projects—steal the ones that match your goals.

20 Complete AI Projects

Each project lists objective, tools, setup, workflow, and results. Adapt freely.

Project 1: AI Content Creation Studio

OBJECTIVE Publish 12 posts/month · **TOOLS** ChatGPT/Claude, Canva/Ideogram, Buffer

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Voice bible + calendar → batch drafts → image prompts → schedule

Results: Consistent pipeline; 4+ hours saved weekly

Project 2: Personal AI Research Desk

OBJECTIVE Brief any topic in 45 minutes · **TOOLS** Perplexity, NotebookLM, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Search → save sources → notebook → 1-page brief

Results: Reusable research SOP

Project 3: Freelance Proposal Engine

OBJECTIVE Faster, clearer proposals · **TOOLS** ChatGPT Projects, Notion

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Intake form → discovery summary → proposal draft → human price

Results: Higher close rate via clarity

Project 4: AI Customer Support Desk

OBJECTIVE Faster first responses · **TOOLS** NotebookLM, Zendesk/Help Scout, Zapier

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Policy notebook → draft replies → approval → macros

Results: Lower first-response time

Project 5: Social Media Manager System

OBJECTIVE Daily multi-platform presence · **TOOLS** Claude, Ideogram, scheduling tool

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Pillar content → atomize → visuals → schedule

Results: One idea → many assets

Project 6: YouTube / Shorts Factory

OBJECTIVE Weekly video output · **TOOLS** ChatGPT, Veo/Runway, ElevenLabs, CapCut

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Script → voice → b-roll gen → edit → SEO package

Results: Faster packaging

Project 7: AI Marketing Offer Lab

OBJECTIVE Test offers quickly · **TOOLS** ChatGPT, Perplexity, Sheets

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: ICP research → offer variants → landing copy → ad hooks

Results: Structured experimentation

Project 8: Course Creator Companion

OBJECTIVE Outline to lessons · **TOOLS** NotebookLM, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Source uploads → module map → lesson scripts → quizzes

Results: Complete curriculum skeleton

Project 9: Meeting OS

OBJECTIVE Zero lost action items · **TOOLS** Fireflies/Zoom, ChatGPT, Todoist

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Transcript → actions → tasks → follow-up mail

Results: Accountability habit

Project 10: Sales Call Coach

OBJECTIVE Improve discovery · **TOOLS** Claude, CRM

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Transcript critique vs scorecard → coaching notes

Results: Rep skill growth

Project 11: E-commerce Listing Booster

OBJECTIVE Better PDPs · **TOOLS** ChatGPT, Ideogram, Shopify

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Feature list → benefits copy → image set → SEO fields

Results: Listing velocity

Project 12: HR Onboarding Kit

OBJECTIVE Smoother new hires · **TOOLS** Gemini/Docs, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Role scorecard → 30-60-90 → FAQ notebook

Results: Less repeated questions

Project 13: Local Business Demo Package

OBJECTIVE Sell AI services to SMBs · **TOOLS** Make/Zapier, ChatGPT

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Lead form automation + review response drafts + weekly report

Results: Productized freelance offer

Project 14: Investor Update Assistant

OBJECTIVE Monthly updates in 30 min · **TOOLS** Sheets, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Metrics paste → narrative → risks → ask

Results: Consistent investor comms

Project 15: Podcast Production Pack

OBJECTIVE Episode → assets · **TOOLS** Claude, ElevenLabs, Suno (optional)

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Outline → script → show notes → audiograms prompts

Results: Faster turnaround

Project 16: Grant / RFP Drafter

OBJECTIVE Structured applications · **TOOLS** NotebookLM, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Requirements notebook → compliance matrix → draft answers

Results: Fewer missed criteria

Project 17: Personal Tutoring Bot

OBJECTIVE Exam prep · **TOOLS** ChatGPT, NotebookLM

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Notes notebook → daily drills → weak-topic focus

Results: Measurable practice loop

Project 18: Brand Design Sprint

OBJECTIVE Visual direction in a day · **TOOLS** Midjourney/Flux, Claude

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Mood prompts → select 3 directions → style card

Results: Aligned creative brief

Project 19: Ops SOP Library

OBJECTIVE Document tribal knowledge · **TOOLS** Claude, Notion

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Interview transcript → SOP → checklist → quiz

Results: Trainable processes

Project 20: AI Automation Mini-Agency

OBJECTIVE Retainers from workflows · **TOOLS** Make or n8n, LLM API

Setup: Create a Project/folder, paste a one-paragraph brief, and add brand or policy sources.

Workflow: Audit client tasks → 3 Zaps/scenarios → dashboard

Results: Recurring revenue offer

Action Steps

1. Pick one project and complete it in 7 days.
2. Write a case study: before → after → hours saved.
3. Productize your winning project as a freelance offer or internal SOP.

PART 12

The Future & Your Roadmap

Tools will change. Your learning system shouldn't. Finish with trends and a 12-month plan.

Future Trends

- **Agents:** more tool-using assistants with workplace permissions
- **Multimodal:** seamless text ↔ image ↔ audio ↔ video in one thread
- **Robotics:** foundation models meeting physical hardware (slower, high impact)
- **AGI debate:** progress continues; timelines uncertain—skills still compound
- **Careers:** AI operators, automation specialists, AI product managers, domain experts who wield AI

TIMELESS SKILLS

Problem framing, prompting, verification, workflow design, domain expertise, and ethics will outlast any single app.

Trends that matter to beginners

The future of AI can sound abstract, but the practical implication is simple: more work will move from "open a blank page" to "brief, supervise, verify, and improve." Beginners should not try to predict every model release. Build durable habits that improve with any tool: clear instructions, good source material, thoughtful review, and workflow design.

Trend	What it means in practice	Beginner move
Multimodal tools	Text, images, audio, video, files, and screens work together.	Practice uploading real materials and asking specific questions.
Longer context	Models can work with bigger documents and project histories.	Learn source curation and document hygiene.
Agents	AI will take more multi-step actions with tools.	Study automation, permissions, logging, and approval gates.
On-device AI	Some AI runs locally on phones and computers.	Watch for privacy-friendly workflows and offline assistants.
Regulation and provenance	Disclosure, rights, and audit trails matter more.	Keep records of prompts, sources, licenses, and human review.

AI Career Roadmap

Beginner (Months 1–3)

- Daily LLM practice; finish Parts 1–4 of this book
- Build Playbook with 30 prompts
- Ship 2 projects from Chapter 28

Intermediate (Months 4–8)

- Add image/video/audio for your niche
- Build 5 automations with approval gates
- Create a Custom GPT / Claude Project for your job
- Publish case studies

Advanced (Months 9–12)

- Design agentic workflows with logging and evals
- Specialize (support, marketing ops, research, education)
- Teach or consult; productize a service

12-month learning plan (summary)

Quarter	Focus	Proof
Q1	LLM fluency + prompting	Playbook + 2 projects
Q2	Multimodal content	Portfolio of assets
Q3	Automation	5 live workflows
Q4	Agents + specialization	Case study + offer

Key Takeaways

- Practice daily in real work, not only demos.
- Proof beats certificates: projects, SOPs, metrics.
- Specialize after you have general fluency.

Action Steps

1. Block 30 minutes daily for AI practice this week.
2. Choose your 12-month specialization hypothesis.
3. Schedule a monthly review of your AI Playbook.

You reached the end of *The Complete Beginner's Guide to Artificial Intelligence* (2026 Handbook Edition). The tools will evolve—your ability to brief, verify, and build workflows is the durable advantage. Now open your AI Playbook and ship Project #1.